

Appendix two: Intensive Interaction

I was recently asked to produce five top tips for using Intensive Interaction. Wanting to get a broad view, I made the mistake of canvassing the experience of five top practitioners – and got back around 25 different suggestions. Not easy to put into sets and enough to fill a book, or at least an appendix²¹⁹.

But what was interesting was that each clearly reflected their writer's voice, unsurprising perhaps because just like we evolve friendships, Intensive Interaction is about developing a unique relationship with a conversation partner, something we 'share the flavour of', rather than 'do to', each one qualitatively different and totally personal. We all go about it slightly differently. So the summary that is offered (with the help of my co-communicators) is in the sense of guidelines rather than rules. We all develop our own style.

To begin with, Intensive Interaction, or 'Responsive Communication' as I prefer to think of it, uses body language to communicate with partners with whom we find it difficult to get in touch. Usually non-verbal, the approach can also be used to accompany and ease interaction with partners who do have speech, just as we all, autistic or not, use body language (positive and negative) with each other to convey how we feel.

Before we even start, we need to lay aside our own agenda, what we think our partner ought to be doing. This can be difficult in a goal-orientated culture. However, it really does help to empty the mind and place ourselves wholly at the disposal of our partner. Our attitude needs to be, 'I am here for you'. My aim is to be with them and whatever they find interesting in the fullest sense.

²¹⁹Thanks to Janet Gurney, Penny Mytton, Jemma Swales, Nicola Wightman and Michelle O'Neill.

Personally, although I may spend a little time with staff before getting started (finding out if there is anything my partner particularly dislikes), I do not spend a lot of time in pre-engagement observation (since my mere presence may raise tension) but ease my way in as our encounter presents itself. I avoid verbal introductions, since these set the wrong context. So my initial greeting will reflect a sound they are making, or a movement, or the answer to a rhythm.

Each partner has their own language and I feel like a beginner every time. Sooner or later we are going to have to take the plunge, and the advice here is 'just do it', 'give it a go'. We do not have to be experts – mothers and infants are doing it all the time and it is quite a good idea to borrow a friend's baby to practice on. They are very responsive. But it is crucial to remember that we are not infantilising our partners, treating them as babies. By sending signals that the brain can easily process, we are reducing sensory overload, so that the brain recognises at least something in the environment and can more easily negotiate their everyday experience. Cut out body language and we should present as robots.

Look not only at what they are doing but for the specific physical sensations their action is sending back to the brain. This feedback may not be the same as their action, so try their activity yourself and see what you get out of it. Work from this.

Don't use props. If you do, both your attention and your partner's will focus on what is known as the 'third object'. You may feel naked, but you are the best piece of equipment you have. What is essential to engagement is the one-on-one interaction. The only thing you need is you.

Your partner's language will probably include a number of different elements and the ones that have the most meaning for them and to which they most easily respond are not always the most obvious. Watch out for small movements and rhythms and listen for quiet sounds. These may be very small indeed – as little as breathing rhythm or a scratching finger, anything that your partner is using to give themselves physical feedback. You want to know how it is they are 'talking to themselves'.

Join in, bearing in mind that what you are trying to do is establish conversation, so although you may start by using imitation, think of answering and responding rather than copying or mimicking. Timing is

very important – give your partner space to reply (which may mean waiting for some considerable time). Don't rush them: use pauses.

Look not just for what they are doing, but how they are doing it, since this will tell you how they feel. You need to tune in to that feeling with empathy.

Show them you are listening through your own body language. For example, leaving your face open and inclining your head to one side expresses your attention. (And they will be able to decode your body language if you are presenting it in the context of their language.)

Watch the body/face to see if there is any response at all. This may be as little as a flicker of the eyelids, or they may turn to you, give eye contact, show some form of interest. Their expression may become attentive or thoughtful. If they turn away it may be because they wish to withdraw, but alternatively it may be because they are deaf and wish to present their best ear. (If they withdraw, draw back a bit yourself and try again, presenting the sound or movement slightly differently, or try another sound.) Base your next move on their response. Take turns, as in conversation.

Allow your partner to determine proximity. They may feel uncomfortable if you sit too close. I tend to sit beside rather than opposite to avoid direct eye contact, which can be painful. One can even work with sounds from the next room.

Extemporise within the context of their language, using variations drawn from their own repertoire. So movement might be answered by a sound (one of theirs) or a rhythmic movement by tapping. Difference can also be expressed by altering the rhythm slightly. Or put two elements, such as rhythm and sound, together. You will get attention by straight copying but the element of surprise in 'difference' motivates your partner to want to come back for more. 'I recognise that but there is something odd that intrigues my attention.'

Once your partner understands that if they make an initiative they will get an answer, they will normally try testing you out. Look for anything new that your partner introduces, if you miss it you will send the message that you are not listening to them. Within the limits of any learning disability that may or may not be present, they will generalise: 'if I scratch my nose she will respond but what happens if I bang the floor?'

And once we have mastered their language, like a verbal conversation, it does not matter who starts off: we can kick-start interaction by using one of their initiatives. Just say 'Hello' in their language. It might be a wave or tapping that is part of their rhythm or a welcoming sound they recognise as theirs.

Sometimes when there is no response it can feel as though one is being rejected and this can be discouraging. Responses may be small and take time. But the most common difficulty is that we get stuck in a routine or game and start wondering what to do next. This can happen if we just copy – the brain habituates and needs the slight jolt of surprise (given by responding unusually but within their repertoire) to open out the conversation again. (If I was talking to you and repeated the same thing over and over again I should not be surprised if you got bored). Other difficulties are 'over-excitement' and over-attachment. The former can be avoided by remembering the anxiety that is central to the lives of those on the spectrum and avoiding 'hyping them up' by exaggerating their sounds. Always aim to calm and centre your partner by bringing their sounds down. The danger of over-attachment should be addressed by working as a member of a team: involving all those who are engaged with them.

Intensive Interaction is sometimes thought of as being used in sessions but ideally it becomes just part of the way that we interact with our partner, so that, in a confused sensory setting, they are always being offered something that has meaning for them.

Filming or working in pairs really helps us to improve our practice, since we cannot pick up everything that is going on at once and need to go back and reflect on what we are doing and where we have missed out, not in a sense of judgement but so that we can engage more fully with our partners and they with us next time. It is good when they want to be with people.

Interaction is sometimes very powerful and often moving. The final piece of advice from my practitioner colleagues is to relax, enjoy it, and to have fun.